
ARGUE INTO THE CAMERA, PLEASE: AN EXPLORATION OF COMPREHENSIVE DIGITAL RECORDING IN DEBATE

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One of my most significant coaching experiences--as a debater--occurred shortly before CEDA Nationals in 1990. My coaching staff videotaped several demonstration speeches, including mine, and then sat down with debaters to discuss strengths and weaknesses. One noteworthy weakness was my tendency to speak in paragraphs, unflowable streams of consciousness. Watching helped correct the problem and I had the good fortune to end my debate career on a high note. Upon my return as the Director at Missouri State University, constructive use of videotape was one of my top priorities, and one that has paid substantial dividends.

Since the spring of 2004, I have videotaped nearly every round judged or watched. For the first couple of years, I used an older Gateway camera; now, a newer Sanyo provides better video and audio quality. During the last three years, I have accumulated hundreds of debate round videos in digital formats – enough to overwhelm a 100GB server. Occasional recording of major elimination debates is a long standing practice yet the ease of digital storage and the small size of digital recorders make the practice likely to expand in the near future. Already, there are several in the community taping several rounds per tournament, and debate videos are transferred person-to-person and over web distribution sites. In this essay I explore the implications recordings for NDT/CEDA college debate, explaining my motives

for recording, how recording may impact debate practices, and the implications of expanding access to such recordings.

Original Purposes

Three initial purposes motivated my decision to systematically videotape rounds. First, video provides the round participants a chance to view their performance after the round in complete. Although a taped round may become a valued memento of one's debating days—or, in the alternative, sometime to hide from the future as fashion and expectations change--my experience suggested there is high payoff with immediately seeing how one, externally, looks/sounds and making appropriate adjustments. While some students undoubtedly defend their arguments and clarity, many others begin to see the difference between what they felt they were saying and how the judge perceived it. The objective here is improvement of debating skill. We often focus on taping our own debaters with precisely this objective in mind.

A second purpose is to educate people who are not able to directly observe the debate. This could include people assigned to debate or judge in other rooms, people unable to attend the tournament, people who would like to have seen the round after having heard about it, and people not yet connected to college debate. I have found the interest in the videos is the highest in the final group. Every summer camp bring in new high school debaters that want to see and understand college debate, with several leaving with a small collection of video from notable rounds. I specifically encourage new recruits to watch video before arriving on campus; since our primary recruiting comes from areas unable, by rule, to participate in most national circuit high school debate, video can ease the transition into a new form of the activity. I hope to accumulate a larger collection of video to help train novices without intimidating them.

A final purpose for recording of debates is competitive – a chance to view other teams or arguments to generate better strategies. While we have certainly used video to this end, it is the goal least effectively met. Put simply, the time commitment

involved in close watching for many rounds is difficult to balance with expectations of teaching classes, taking classes, working jobs, and other research assignments. The less engaged students have little interest in doing so, and the most dedicated generally spend their time in other preparation avenues. It is one thing to have “game tape” available, and another thing entirely to make effective use of it.

Impact on Debate Practices

Recording debates has the potential to appreciably impact round content. In addition to skill improvement, probable effects include changes in the scouting/strategizing process, alterations in judging process, and adjustments in competitor choices. The process of round scouting is inherently limited by the number of people available to watch rounds, and it is impossible for active debaters to watch their competitors until deep elimination rounds. Not only does video access create the potential for those not present to observe and learn from a round, but it creates the potential for very close scrutiny of discourse segments through repeated playback. Particularly interesting lines from debates, including notable sound bites, cross examination questions and answers, or short analytical arguments can be scrutinized to plan for the future.

One of the challenges in preparing for debates (and particularly critical argument teams) is the problem of identifying the opponent’s thesis; whether certain kinds of arguments are relevant, and why. A related complication relates to the interpretation of evidence, as the meaning of any quote is more about what it does in the debate round than what it says. In every tournament there are rounds won because the other team misses the thesis of a position, and in many cases blame for misunderstanding is due to ambiguity.

One effective way to force affirmative clarification is adopting a strategy the invites the affirmative to clarify their position. Arguably, negative positions including topicality, counterplans, counter advocacies, and even disadvantages could

be employed for this purpose. However, the practice of allowing affirmatives to win rounds on offense against anything the opponent says, even when those arguments are introduced for the purpose of clarifying ambiguous cases, deters many arguments. One result is teams win rounds by stonewalling in cross examination and then critiquing in-speech arguments designed to clarify another team's ambiguous positions. A second result is that ambiguity distorts competitive equity in favor of the team that understands "what we really mean" over the team trying to find out. Finally, such ambiguity means that the thesis of such arguments often escapes rigorous discussion or deep understanding. Until such time as the policy debate community begins to view arguments which primarily function to clarify the other team's position as something short of advocacy, intentional vagueness will remain strategically useful.

Closely watching rounds on video is an incomplete solution to obfuscation, but it can help debaters to better understand the thesis of the case they are expected to refute, and better formulate discriminating cross examination questions. Furthermore, it also helps to prepare debaters to debate with more confidence against unusual strategies and arguments that would otherwise be outside their comfort zones. Such preparation may not always be positive. I'm aware of one program that requests observers not record its debaters; the concern stems from a round where a negative rewrote the 1AC and delivered it in English Prime.

An additional implication is more cautionary. Over the last several years, there have been arguments or occurrences in debate rounds that risk public relations complications (Atchison & Panetta, 2006). At least one of these has made it into the knowledge of former debaters, leaving me in a position where colleagues have expected me to express my opinions about said strategy. Although the conversation I am referencing did not threaten our program, it is easy to imagine being asked to defend participation in an activity where such events are allowed to occur. This risk is probably magnified to the extent that video of such a round was in circulation.

There is also a risk that video recording of rounds could chill student expression. Imagine a former debater running for office, faced with evidence of their advocating socialism, making the case or difference between strategic arguments in debate versus believing in that argument would be complicated. It has been suggested by some that dispersal of video beyond the debate community could change the relatively safe space that debate rounds create for the expression of unpopular arguments. To the extent that the insularity of debate serves important freedom of speech concerns (the ability to play with arguments without publicly committing to those arguments for an outside audience), there is risk involved in making it less insular. While I am not aware of any debater being deterred from making an argument due to taping the round, I have known a few that for other reasons preferred not to have round videos in general circulation. Being sensitive to these concerns seems implicit in choosing to video record debate rounds, but that sensitivity could decrease over time if recording of rounds becomes more and more common.

Another party potentially impacted by the recording of rounds is the judge. In particular, video of a round could reveal that a judge decided “incorrectly” if their reasoning rested heavily upon factual statements about what was said and this turned out to be incorrect. This process may not be that concerning, as debaters would likely gripe about a decision they considered incorrect with or without video evidence. Furthermore, a video is far more likely to reveal that the argument the debater actually made is weaker or less clear than the argument they recall making, which presumably aids the educational process. The concern would be primarily that the knowledge that a round is being videotaped impacts the judge’s decision making process in some negative manner (as opposed to merely encouraging them to remain diligent). I do not worry too much about these concerns when videotaping rounds that I judge (and, in fact, have occasionally encouraged debaters to cross check the video if they think I was wrong about something), but there is at least the potential to alter a judge’s assessment of a round, perhaps by altering their reliance upon oral features of the round

relative to text based factors, such as evidence quality. The same risk is probably present any time a partisan observer is in the room.

In most cases, the possible effects are either positive (improved scouting increases argument depth), or if negative are quite minimal (most judges are unlikely to change their decision process due to observers or video recording). The one continuing concern is the potential for a round with some controversial process to negatively impact the activity, beyond the particular individuals involved. One of the most widely watched debate round videos is a round that features dancing as argument, and was presumably posted online by one of the participants. Whether such performances are encouraged, deterred, or not affected by the “video evidence” is difficult to conclusively resolve.

Expanding Access to Debate Recordings

In the past individuals have occasionally dubbed videocassettes, but the new technology climate--digital formats and high speed internet connections--make mass distribution realistic. The barriers to widespread distribution, however, remain and are both technical and philosophical, with the second category generating the more perplexing questions.

From the outset, I intended to place recorded videos, assuming the consent of participants, into cyber space. The primary barrier has been the lack of free access to a high bandwidth, high volume private website. University servers could hold videos, but our university’s implementation of the Rehabilitation Act precludes use of university servers for public access without full transcripts of each video. Although this act is intended to assure that training videos, etc., are accessible, it can be read to apply to applications such as debate videos. Given the volume of words in a typical debate, and the volume of videos in our archive, this requirement is onerous. Public services such as YouTube provide the potential for video distribution, though a specialized account is required for file size considerations. Further, such posting would require file translation and tagging for each file, a time consuming preclusion.

The larger question is whether we should post any video. Most of the negative implications for competitive practice become more likely if video is widely disseminated to internal and external communities. It is possible that constituencies interested in defunding or reallocating travel budgets could represent the least impressive video as somehow typical of the activity. The vast majority of debate video, of course, makes a strong argument for the academic depth of policy debate, but representative counter examples may not make up the damage from a single destructive example.

Such concerns are not unique to video recording. Stories of particularly bizarre debate rounds do on occasion spark interest outside of the immediate community. Publicly posted case lists reveal the argument choices of all programs. Even a video recording not shared publicly could be used in a destructive manner. Nonetheless, wider public distribution does entail risk.

Of course, many of the benefits of recording are reached only with wider distribution. At minimum, participants in the round should have a reasonable chance to access video of their performance. I happily share videos with participants, time and technology permitting, and believe that doing will emerge as common practice. (At least one other coach frequently tapes debates and posts them to a blog.) Presumptively, this creates access for their programs as well. If all programs had easy access to several debates, including both top tier debates, typical mid-level debates, and debates involving novice and JV competitors, the resulting video would provide an extremely useful tool for helping younger debaters get a feel for the activity prior to their first tournament experience.

A central question is whether sharing should be *institutionalized*. A password protected, high volume sharing service could achieve the same ends, but it is not clear whether NDT or CEDA are interested in hosting one. Absent that, some sort of private website for community use, parallel to case list and tournament entry websites, seems the most likely near term prospect.

As we move past informal distribution, there is a place for community discussion of videotaping norms. Although non-commercial video recording of public events, such as debates, is unlikely to result in legal liability, the NDT has opted for various forms of participant consent, included implied consent, in regard to commercial recording by College Sports Television (CSTV). As video recording of debates becomes more commonplace, there are bound to be occasional conflicts between the few that prefer their performance be seen only by those present and the growing number committed to video recording in all cases. The conflicts are likely to become issues addressed by tournament invitations, squad policies, and concerned individuals.

Conclusion

While audio and video recording of debates has been a long standing practice, particularly in the case of final rounds, digital recording and internet distribution raise new issues. The expansion of such recordings appears to be a growing community norm, and those openly resisting the practice appear to be in the minority. This minority, however, has concerns and issues which presumably have not reached the entire college debate community, and which are likely to impact the course of the practice.

The expansion of the practice is likely, as with other technological innovations, to impact competitive practice, judging practice, and preparation in a variety of ways. Many of these effects are likely to be positive, raising the quality of preparation and thus the quality of debates. However, the potential for wider public distribution raises some freedom of speech concerns, as it creates the potential to open insular debates to wider audiences, including audiences less likely to understand the differences between making an argument in a debate and personal advocacy. Evaluating the practice thus invokes larger questions about whether debate rounds are, or should be, protected spaces for students to experiment with ideas and concepts they may not fully embrace.

Note

I am occasionally asked about Camera specifications, so I will include them here. The older camera was a Gateway DV-S20 (<http://support.gateway.com/s/camera/7004883/7004883nv.shtml>). I recorded debates onto a 512 MB SD card, and then used a card reader to transfer them to a folder on my hard drive. Each debate was 350-400MB, and I generally burned copies for each debate team onto a CD. After tiring of carrying CD's, I moved to carrying a larger capacity flash drive instead. A round recording generally consisted of 8 computer files, one for each speech (including the CX following each constructive). Each camera was around \$200, with additional costs for batteries and SD cards. The newer camera was a Sanyo Xacti C40 (http://www.sanyo-dsc.com/english/products/vpc_c40/index.html). This camera can handle 2GB SD cards, allowing a whole day of taping prior to hard drive backup. Despite improved image and sound quality, the debates remain about the same file size. Both cameras still have video quality limitations in relatively dark hotel ballrooms, which is unfortunate the best elimination rounds are too often in low light environments.

Reference

Atchison, J. & Panetta, E. (2006). Raising a Stink: An Assessment of Argument Presentation and Effects on Secondary Audiences. In P. Riley (Ed.), *Engaging Argument* (pp. 512-517). Washington, DC: National Communication Association.

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